

THE LESS SOCIABLE SOCIALIST

Behind the fiercely private Marxist is a crime fiction fan and a friend who never forgets

He was Sudhir and she was Rita. Both were underground during the Emergency. On November 7, 1975, they were married in a quiet ceremony attended by Communist veterans. Later, they surfaced as Mr and Mrs Karat. It perhaps befits the 59-year-old CPI(M) General Secretary's almost obsessive love for privacy that he got married while living under a pseudonym. "At a personal level, he is very charming, affectionate and friendly. But yes, he is not an open, gregarious person like Sitaram Yechury," says artist Vivan Sundaram, who is such a close friend that Prakash Karat made a rare social appearance to inaugurate his exhibition in December last year. It is not that the taciturn Marxist likes to enjoy art exhibitions on his own, quite the reverse. He is never seen endorsing an author's book launch—which is quite a fad these days even with other prominent leaders of the Left. But Karat is a genuine friend. When Sundaram wanted to give up art for political activism, it was he who persuaded him otherwise. "He is very sensitive to a person's needs. He could easily have said, here is another person to join the party," says the artist.

His hotspots are humble canteens rather than glittering cocktail evenings. His love for dosa and sambar, which his mother used to cook for him as a child, still drives him to the United Press of India's canteen in Delhi. The only party he knows is CPI(M). "He talked a lot about A.K. Gopalan, but if there was any role model in his life, it was P. Sundarayya, once party general secretary, who shaped his life," recalls D.P. Tripathi, NCP leader and a friend of Karat's from his Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) days. It was Gopalan, however, who sent him to JNU,

not so much for higher studies as to build the party's student wing Student's Federation of India in 1970. "So many girls in the university had a crush on him. But I recall only Brinda in his life," says Tripathi. Karat's trademark wardrobe of khaki trousers and half-sleeve shirts is another throwback from his childhood. Few recall seeing him in a suit and tie. In winter, however, he adds more colour to his clothes by way of sweaters.

Reticent since childhood, Karat spends most of his time reading not just books on world affairs and political economy, but also crime thrillers. He has not been to a cinema hall in years. The last film he watched—a month ago—was *Pardesi*, a Malayalam movie made by party MLA from Kerala, P.T. Kunju Mohammed. And this film is about Indians in the Gulf. Sundaram's exhibition, too, had a social angle.

His play is as politically correct as his work. Karat's holidays are usually spent with his brother-in-law and sister-in-law, Prannoy and Radhika Roy. The destinations vary from Tuscany to Goa. Brinda, who studied at Dehradun's Welham Girls School, was so moved by the Vietnam War that she joined



MARRIED TO A CAUSE: There is a fine line between the Karats' personal and public lives

the Marxist movement after a stint with Air-India. In 2005, she was elected to the CPI(M) Politburo as its first woman member. Although Mr and Mrs Karat work out of the same office building in Delhi, there is a fine line between their personal and public lives. Karat's hair is almost white and his wry sense of humour seems lost in the dry details of the nuclear deal. Earlier, when asked about the induction of more women members in the party, he had quipped, "This is not the Communist Party of India (Male)." **by Priya Sahgal and Satarupa Bhattacharjya**

lic, respecting their commitments to the coalition. CPI(M) members say Karat's contention was that the president's post was constitutional and thus, not an issue to fight for. But in return for the Left's vote, Karat ensured that his nominee Mohammad Hamid Ansari was the Left-UPA candidate for the vice-president's post. Lok Sabha Speaker Somnath Chatterjee's desire for the post might have remained unfulfilled, but with him and Ansari chairing the two Houses, the Left's symbolic control over Parliament was complete.

As a politician, he has only two phobias: communal-

ism—a convenient euphemism for BJP—and America. Outside the confines of AKG Bhavan, he is a gentleman comrade who is friendly with other parties. He opposed the dismissal of the Mulayam Singh Government in Uttar Pradesh after an adverse judicial judgement. BJP and the Congress had struck an understanding that the dismissal would get the necessary parliamentary approval, but Karat told the prime minister that CPI(M) would not allow it. He even supported Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi on the question of Ram Setu. When Health Minister Ambumani